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THEOLOGICAL METHOD AND GORDON KAUFMAN

Gordon Kaufman is a theologian who wrestles with essential theological issues. In a recent amplification of his position, *An Essay on Theological Method*,¹ he makes an honest attempt to describe the method by which a self-critical theologian might work. This paper sets out a critique of the method Kaufman proposes and from that delineates a path which theologians might choose to follow.

KAUFMAN'S THEOLOGICAL METHOD

Theology, for Kaufman, is a public activity of general significance which can no longer base its thinking on some authoritatively given dogma or experience or revelation of God neatly tied up in a book. Theology is an attempt to understand our faith and religious life, to understand how our religious symbols function, to criticise, reinterpret and reconstruct them so as to enable them to achieve their purpose more adequately.² Theology is a human endeavour.

The central concept of theology, that term to which all other theological concepts are tied, is that of God. All language uses, including those of the Church and theology, are built on ordinary language use. And ordinary language becomes specifically theological precisely when its terms are pre-sided over by the concept God. Theology's starting point, then, must be the concept God and its use in ordinary language.³

And what is the ordinary use of the word God which must be the starting point for theology? 'The word "God" appears to designate the last or ultimate point or reference to which all action, consciousness and reflection can lead.'⁴ Such an ultimate reference point is indispensable for it is that which unifies the plurality of life (God is only one of such words used by our culture – another would be matter – even if it be the most frequent ground used). It can never be one of the items of experience (and so reached) since it relativizes them all. This is the logical or formal function of the word God; God as a limiting idea, the absolute relativizer.⁵

¹ Gordon D. Kaufman, *An Essay on Theological Method* (Missoula, Montana: Scholars Press, 1975).

² *Ibid.* pp. x-xi and 1-8.

³ *Ibid.* pp. 8-11.

⁴ *Ibid.* p. 11.

⁵ *Ibid.* pp. 11-15.

Theology, according to Kaufman, is a process of construction, as opposed to description. We cannot perceive God as an object for description, for God is beyond all such perceivable objects. Neither is the concept world an object of experience and able to be described. Both must be constructed. Theology's intent is to construct a world which supplies unity and meaningfulness to life, and a concept God which relativizes the concept world and enables this humanization to happen in its fullness.¹ Kaufman continues this theme in the Epilogue to the *Essay* by briefly exploring the question of truth for our theologies. He suggests that the only criteria we have for assessing theological claims are 'pragmatic and humanistic':²

Thus a theological construct may be regarded as true – in the only sense of 'true' properly applicable here – if it in fact leads to a fruitful life, in the broadest and fullest and most comprehensive sense possible. We can never jump out of our concept of the world, or of God, in order to see if the 'real world' and the 'real God' correspond to those concepts; we have no independent source of information about them which can provide a check on our ideas. The only test we can apply is to see how satisfactorily these ideas do the intellectual and cultural work for which they have been constructed.

Kaufman proceeds to outline his 'three moments of theological construction',³ the order in which theologizing should proceed. Its first task is to build a concept of world, the whole (another important construct) of reality, using metaphors and models to depict the world as we feel it really is and yet having the potential of being relativized by a concept God. The theologian's second task is to fill out the already assumed formal understanding of God (God as ultimate limit) with other models, initially describing the relationship between God and the world, and so relativize the already constructed concept of world. The concept of God must also have 'a humanized and humanizing quality which the concept of world lacks'.⁴ Kaufman outlines five major considerations for developing a concept of God: the formal requirements of the relationship between the first and second movements of theological construction (God relativizing the world); the human significance of the models used (their 'religious power and moral implications');⁵ the logical considerations of consistency and coherence; aesthetic considerations; and the 'interests, problems and needs' of the situation within which the theologian is working.⁶ The third movement is a reformulation of the concept world so that it fits intelligibly with the newly derived concept of God, producing a 'theological' world.

There are three topics, however, arising from Kaufman's *Essay* which I want to look at in particular. They are: (1) his manner of choosing the

¹ *Ibid.* pp. 19–38.

³ *Ibid.* pp. 41–64.

⁵ *Ibid.* p. 55.

² *Ibid.* p. 72.

⁴ *Ibid.* p. 52.

⁶ *Ibid.*

theological starting point; (2) the content of his starting point with suggestions for a theological epistemology; and (3) the criteria used for assessing theologies.

THE THEOLOGICAL STARTING POINT

Basic to Kaufman's theological scheme is his assumption that cardinal to the nature of God is God's absolute otherness. This I want to investigate from a number of vantage points. First of all, I wish to look at his manner of taking a starting point for theology.

(a) *Revelation, dogma and religious experience.* Kaufman suggests that we should start theology with the word God and in particular its use in ordinary language. The starting point for theology cannot be revelation given to us by God (although it may conclude with this and may admit that this is primary in the order of being), or the dogmas of the Church, for these presuppose the concepts of God and revelation. What are the meanings and proper uses of these words? Neither can theology's starting point be religious experience, for all experience depends on and is moulded by language, and to start with religious experience (as with revelation and dogma) presupposes concepts whose meanings and uses should be scrutinized. Experience – especially new experience – acts rather as the last court of appeal or testing ground for theology, since the meaning of concepts exists in their shaping and interpreting experience.¹

The case is probably not as cut and dried as Kaufman would like to make out, for he too is assuming a starting point which determines the content of his concept God. But let me make two points first. Discussion on the nature of God for the revelationists, dogmatists and experientialists is not always circular as Kaufman's position might imply, for they do not always find their concept of God as assumed at the beginning writ large and confirmed by religious experience or the content of revelation, etc. In fact it is often the case that their concepts of God are found lacking and need revision. Moreover, they could suggest that their concepts of God, even though they are inherited from culture and language, are historically derived from experiences of God or revelation. They could suggest that they are merely using and assuming a concept whose use and meaning were in previous generations derived from religious experience or revelation.

Kaufman suggests that to start with revelation or religious experience or dogma presupposes the concept God as used in common discourse. Therefore we should start with common use when seeking to understand the concept God. But this presupposes a linguistic functionalism which says that the meaning of a word is tied to its use in common language. He has another philosophical starting point too, and that is an empiricism reflected in his

¹ *Ibid.* pp. 1–8.

rationalistic approach to the doing of theology (even to the point of considering theological *method*), and his (supposed – although this is not stated and will be discussed later in this paper) means of obtaining the *common* use of the word God by some concensual method (a testing of hypotheses of what constitutes common use to find if that really is the common use). I am not saying it is wrong to make these assumptions (and they are much more secular than those which a revelationalist or experientialist or dogmatist would take), but that Kaufman is making assumptions at a level similar to those made by people of competing starting points. His may make more sense for our empirical age and thus seem more reasonable, but that is a relative judgement which we should acknowledge as such.

(b) *Choosing the use and meaning of the word God.* Let us accept that theological discourse is founded on the concept God and that this word's use is given to us in our ordinary language. Kaufman then suggests what is this normal use. 'God', he says, functions as a limiting and relativizing word, unifying all experience by being its ground and unapproachable point of reference.¹ This is what is at the centre of our modern western use of the word 'God' (it is 'our' God we are seeking to understand and we are not interested at this point in how other cultures and traditions use their equivalent terms).

It is interesting to note the attempts Kaufman has made at justifying this as an intelligible starting point and core meaning for our understanding of God. A former attempt of his was to generalize it analogically on the concrete human experience of being limited, especially on the human self as a personal and hidden reality.² Kai Nielsen and Michael McLain severely criticized such attempts of Kaufman's since, for instance, he included a dualism in his notion of the human self which prohibited the intelligibility of his concept of ultimate limit.³ Don Wiebe also criticized Kaufman's attempt at making talk of transcendence intelligible, especially of Kaufman's (apparently inconsistent) move from what he sees as the four modes of human experience of limitation to that of the ultimate limit.⁴ It seems in this later *Essay* Kaufman intends to justify the concept of God as the ultimate limit from another angle, that of ordinary language use.

Why should we accept the particular use of the word which Kaufman suggests as that assumed by ordinary language? Why should we accept this one as opposed to another, say God as the 'Supreme being, Creator and Ruler of [the] Universe',⁵ or that 'God' is a word which functions to point out that all will be well in the end, that the loving and caring forces which

¹ *Ibid.* pp. 11–15.

² See the various articles in Gordon D. Kaufman, *God the Problem* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press, 1972).

³ Kai Nielsen, *Scepticism* (London: Macmillan Press, 1973), pp. 73–84; F. Michael McLain, 'On Theological Models', *Harvard Theological Review*, LXII, 2 (April 1969), 155–87. Kaufman replies to McLain, and in a measure agrees, in *God the Problem*, pp. xiii–xviii.

⁴ Don Wiebe, 'On Kaufman's Problem God', *Religious Studies*, x (June 1974), 189–98.

⁵ *Concise Oxford Dictionary*.

impinge upon us are stronger than the hurting and hating forces? What are the criteria by which Kaufman made this choice? Is it a special insight he has? Or did he ask millions of people what they thought were the functions of the word 'God' and average them out? But then we could also ask why Kaufman should select a seemingly *empty* logical function (God as the ultimate limit) as opposed to a more material function. Why should he select a *function* of the word as opposed to a *meaning*, as if only the former exists in ordinary language? What is so special about a function that no meanings are considered?

What I am suggesting is that it is not sufficient for Kaufman to *tell* us that the basic belief or use or concept for God is as an ultimate relativizer, that this is the ordinary use of the word. He needs further criteria and analysis for selecting some use or meaning for our ordinary God language. It might be that Kaufman has selected this for historical reasons (Barthian correction against the Liberals), or because he has found this the basic use of the word in his experience and development as a theologian. But his waving the magic wand 'ordinary language use' will not necessarily produce the desired golden carriage.

(c) *Is there a common use?* Kaufman needs to specify the criteria for selecting the basic use or meaning of the word 'God' from common discourse, but this may be of no assistance anyway, for within the normal use of the word 'God' there may not be one common use. The word 'God' may mean and be used by different people in quite different ways, yet related along the lines of Wittgenstein's family resemblances as he discusses this in relation to the word game.¹ Some think of God as life itself, while others see God as a being who is outside space and time. There may not necessarily be any use or meaning in common to all common uses and meanings of the word God.

Kaufman might object that to suggest that God is, say, life itself, is not the God he is meaning but some other god (as with the gods of other religions) and it is the God of our western Christian tradition to which he is referring. However, this means there are guidelines for deciding which concept of God he considers might be relevant here (or adequate; for instance we might need the notion of God as Creator), and these guidelines imply another basis for the word's use and meaning. If the criteria for the choice of a basis for selecting the meaning of the word 'God' are to do with tradition or the Bible (defining, say, what is hubris, idolatry, etc.)² then the content of revelation and tradition become part of the starting point for theology. Moreover, it is not as if all such uses presuppose the use of 'God' as the ultimate limit or relativizer; God as life itself is not a totally limiting concept, not utterly beyond all things, for it does not limit life.

¹ Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, transl. By G. E. M. Anscombe (3rd edn New York: Macmillan, 1968), pp. 31e–32e; and his *The Blue and Brown Books* (New York: Harper and Row, 1965), p. 17.

² Kaufman, *Essay*, p. 48.

(d) *Is God a life unifier?* Kaufman suggests, however, that we need a unifier for our lives, that this is indispensable and has been the function mainly of the concept God. Since we are seeking an understanding of theology *for us* and so are discussing our *present* use of language, we can ask if the majority of modern westerners commonly have a unifier for their lives, and if so is this God. Perhaps people do need such a unifier, but do they have one? I think the answer must be in the negative for the majority of modern westerners, and if there is a unifier it is not God but often 'me' or money or matter.¹ Those who are religious enough to use the word God in a non-swearing and deeply meaningful way often find their lives in different sections, disunified: the secular portion of life and the religious.² It is certainly not clear that God functions 'most frequently' as 'the reality in which all life and meaning is grounded'.³

And even if God were a unifier for people's lives, that does not necessarily mean that the word 'God' functions for them as an ultimate limiter. Kaufman suggests that the foundation of all could be seen as matter,⁴ but this does not limit all, it is not beyond all (as Kaufman implies) since it does not limit matter itself.

(e) *Room for change in theology.* If we are to accept this logical function of the word 'God' as the basis for theology, something we have derived from the use of the word in ordinary language, what room is there for change (especially change instigated and guided by theology) in the use and meaning of the word? Or does change take place in the more material aspects of the word which are added at the later constructive stages of the theological movement? Does Kaufman feel there is something eternal about the concept of God which he has isolated as this logical function (something perhaps hard to prove)?⁵

I hope not. I hope that the theologian can be creative and suggest new meanings and uses even as far as the foundational use of the word is concerned, and especially as far as changing the common use of the word. If the word 'God' is ceasing to have a unifying function as it perhaps used to have, maybe the time has come for us to grow into new uses of the word which allow for unification (and as I said above, this does not imply God needs to be an ultimate limiter), and theologians need to suggest new uses and meanings which go beyond any ordinary use. Does Kaufman's scheme

¹ Not all consider it good or necessary to unify our lives; see David L. Miller, *The New Polytheism: Rebirth of the Gods and Goddesses* (New York: Harper and Row, 1974).

² See Don Cupitt, *Worlds of Science and Religion* (New York: Hawthorn Books, 1976), chapter 8; and his 'God and the Future of Man', in *Man and Nature*, ed. by Hugh Montefiore (London: William Collins Sons, 1975).

³ Kaufman, *Essay*, p. 14.

⁴ *Ibid.* p. 13.

⁵ A similar point is made by Cynthia M. Campbell in her 'On "The Three Moments of Theological Construction"' (mimeographed paper presented to the seminar on theological method Kaufman mentions on p. xii of his *Essay*), pp. 3-4.

allow for this? Or is theology forever tied to Kaufman's perception of a use of the word 'God'?

(f) *The starting point and the rest of the scheme.* Before I consider the content of Kaufman's essential theological concept, I should mention that the remainder of Kaufman's discussion on theological method – this meta-theology which one would hope might be independent of theological stance – is in fact dependent on this one basic understanding he has. When he discusses theological construction, for instance, he says that theology cannot be descriptive, for God is beyond all and is not a perceivable object to be described; theology, therefore, is purely constructive, and the court of appeal for the constructs is finally the sense they make of life and the sort of life they encourage. His meaning for the phrase 'theology is construction' is then beyond the obvious meaning that theology is a process of creating models and metaphors, theology being thus a human activity.¹ Further in his plan for theology, when he describes the actual doing of theology (his 'three moments of theological construction') the core of his suggestion is construction of the concept world which is radically relativized by God, and a concept God which can be a radical relativizer.

Perhaps it is not surprising that his (or any other, for that matter) comprehension of what it is (or should be) to be doing theology rests on his own theological assumptions, trimmed down to the naked bones as they may be, and are, in Kaufman's case. If a theologian feels that what Kaufman sees as essential for the word God is in fact true (as many would), they may well like to follow Kaufman's prescription for theological method. Perhaps it is inescapable for us to make some such commitment, especially on such a core word as God, and our theological methodologies are dependent on these. A question which remains, and which I will look at later, concerns the basis for deciding on such commitments. It is a matter of choosing the 'best' relative idea (God as an ultimate relativizer is such a relative idea) for our basic theological assumption and starting point.

KAUFMAN'S UNDERSTANDING OF GOD

There are problems with Kaufman's theological starting point beyond his suggestion for finding such a point. The concept he chooses is itself fraught with problems.

(a) *Relativizing the relativizer.* Kaufman suggests that the word 'God' functions so as to limit and relativize all concepts. Presumably this use of the word would also act to limit itself; what does it mean to say that 'all concepts are relativized by the concept God' is also relativized by the concept

¹ This is all that is required to say that theology is a human and public activity; see Kaufman *Essay*, p. x; see also Gordon D. Kaufman, 'Christian Theology and the Modernization of the Religions', *Bangalore Theological Forum*, viii, 2 (July–Dec. 1976), 90.

God? This is equivalent to being critical of Barth's insistence on God being beyond all human knowledge, and yet this itself is knowledge of God. Does it mean that this relativization process is not an adequate process and needs replacing by something else?¹ Surely such a logical procedure is not exempt from the criticism of the material aspects of the concept God; should the exalted status we give to logic and rationality exclude it from its own stringencies?

It appears that Kaufman wishes to place a great gulf between material concepts and formal concepts; but is such a gulf justifiable? His use of the terms also shows some confusion. He insists that this formal notion of God which he isolates 'does not really tell us *what* God is at all; rather it provides us with a rule that we are advised to use in trying to think of him'. Kaufman elaborates on this:²

In the search for God we must always press on, never resting content with what we have discovered or expressed. . . . Whenever we suppose that God has become directly available to us or is in some way (even intellectually) disposable by us, we can be certain it is. . . . not God.

Yet in other places this formal notion appears more a content of the word as opposed to a rule by which we treat all notions of God: 'The word "God" appears to designate the last or ultimate *point* of reference to which all action, consciousness and reflection can lead.'³ Neither is it clear in my mind that a rule governing the function or use of a word is not part of its meaning and content; in other words, it does tell us what God is (an ultimate point of reference) and Kaufman's formal aspect of God is also a material aspect.

(b) *The real and available God*. In his previous book, *God the Problem*, Kaufman posed this problem concerning the nature of religious language in a pair of words he coined, the real God and the available God. The available God is what we know of God in our concepts of him, and the real God is in principle unknowable since he must relativize even our concepts of him.⁴

There has been a deal of criticism of this suggestion of Kaufman's. Thomas Idinopulos, for instance, asks how the real, hidden God is related to the available and acting God. 'How do we know that the God we find in our experience is the real God who acts and not a false God of our own construction?'⁵ However, suggests Paul Sponheim, Kaufman has isolated some sort of connection between the real and the available God, since, for instance, the

¹ Hugh Jones suggests that it might 'be more correct simply to say that one has no tools for this task' of knowing about God himself, rather than making the formal statement that God is ultimately 'a mysterious and unknowable X' (Kaufman, *God the Problem*; p. 150); see Hugh O. Jones, 'Gordon Kaufman's Perspectival Language', *Religious Studies*, xiv (March 1978), 94.

² Kaufman, *Essay*, p. 49.

³ *Ibid.* p. 11; italics mine.

⁴ Kaufman, *God the Problem*, p. 86. This distinction is a necessary characteristic of the available God; see *ibid.* p. 113.

⁵ Thomas A. Idinopulos, 'The "Ultimate Cosmic Agency"', *The Christian Century*, LXXXIX, 25 (28, June 1972), 719-21.

distinction itself depends on a covert appeal to the real God. This connection, he suggests, needs developing.¹ Alvin Porteus suggests, however, that Kaufman is intending that the relationship between the real God and the available God is a postulate of faith verifiable only in its ability to be 'humanizing' (as Kaufman later puts it);² there is no objective way of determining the relationship.³ Jones caps it all by saying that Kaufman's distinction is 'not only "highly dialectical"...; it is downright confusing'.⁴

(c) *Theological language as functional.* If theological language is not descriptive, then how can we talk about 'truth' in a theological context? Is not saying that a theological concept is more truthful than another equivalent to considering it a more accurate description of divine reality? Are those who say this is to be so deceived? Kaufman attempts to face this question of the home of truth with a specific understanding of the 'reality' of God.

Perhaps I could build up to Kaufman's position this way. We usually use language in an objective way; that is, if we use a noun or an adjective we usually assume that the referent (be that a quality, physical object, psychological state, or whatever) has objective existence, and we use language as if this were so. This appears justified with such words as chair or hair (even if we do not perceive all there might be to perceive about a chair), but becomes questionable when we refer to a person: does a personality have an objective existence? Nevertheless, we use language as if this were so. When it comes to talk of world or God, this problem becomes more apparent, for on reflection many of our uses of these words have no referent. For example, we cannot say the world (which includes the concept of 'whole') *in toto* has an objective existence which we can perceive.⁵ Neither does God, even though he used to be thought of as having an objective existence – as the King of the Heavens, all meant quite literally – which has now been discredited. We use language as if there were objective referents ('Our Father in Heaven', 'I pray to God') and hence we automatically assume there are such referents, and are surprised when on reflection we realize there are no referents directly perceivable (perceived within our own

¹ Paul Sponheim, Review of *God the Problem, Dialog*, 14, no. 1 (Winter 1975), 65–6.

² See the Epilogue in his *Essay*, and his paper 'Christian Theology and the Modernization of the Religions'.

³ Alvin C. Porteus, review of *God the Problem, Religion in Life*, 42, no. 1 (Spring 1973), 131–2.

⁴ Jones, p. 95. See also David R. Griffin, 'Gordon Kaufman's Theology: Some Questions', *Journal of the American Academy of Religions*, xli, 4 (Dec. 1973), 555–8; and Joseph Runzo, review of *An Essay on Theological Method, Theological Studies*, xxxvii (Dec. 1976), 686–7.

⁵ Kaufman suggests (p. 22 of his *Essay*), after Kant, that problems arise when we consider the world as an object of perception. Is it infinite or finite in extent? Did it have a beginning in time?, etc. such problems modern physical cosmology, however, considers it has answers to: the edges of space are defined by gravity and the paths light takes, and the beginning of the world is when the cosmic explosion occurred as in the 'big bang' theories. From the 'inside' of the world we can gain knowledge of the 'whole'. And, anyway, do we experience anything as a whole, or only parts or aspects of it?

experience). The question of the real God, then, is one raised in an automatic response to our use of language, which gives rise to the feeling that there is a real, objective existing God, somewhere and somehow!

Kaufman thinks there is a real God, but not corresponding to any concepts we might have and definitely not describable. Real is being used in another sense to that normally used. *To use language about God, is, rather, to speak about a way of life.* Hence, when Kaufman says that God is the most real of all things, he means, I presume, that the way of life the word God stands for is what defines and is true-life reality for the believer.¹ God is purely a function of our language; the question as to whether there be any real God or not is not answerable, and in fact as it stands is a nonquestion. Rather we should talk about the religious sort of life the word God stands for. Descriptive talk of God might best be left to the believers themselves (who are probably deluded into believing that there is a real God as they think there to be), for the real meaning of the word is more to be found in the sociological and psychological spheres.

Kaufman's is a solution to the demise and presently apparent inadequacies of past theological objectiveness, but perhaps it is not the only solution, nor, in fact, an adequate solution.² It is inadequate to my mind chiefly because *it does not do justice (perhaps even does an injustice) to the believers' feeling for the objective existence of the God they believe in.* The God they know – their available God – is really real, has objective existence, is the real God for them. Moreover, if people knew that what they knew of God is infinitely inadequate or incorrect, the moral code which is associated with the religion is hardly likely to receive compliance. This may be why proportionally fewer people nowadays are holding to traditional Christian morality; the traditional God which that morality stands for is less and less believed in as a forceful reality.

(d) *Kaufman prescribes a description.* In a way Kaufman has taken a description of the process in theology in which theological concepts have proved inadequate, and made it a prescription for theology. We do not think it is adequate now to claim literally that God sits on a throne in the heavens, for instance, or that he is the cause of the blowing of the winds, or that he is merely to be encountered in human subjective experiences. This is a *description* of an historical process. Kaufman rather *prescribes* that the God we conceive cannot be the real God, that God himself infinitely outstrip even our concepts of him. (The same could be said therefore of any person or any

¹ Kaufman, *Essay*, pp. 55–6.

² This type of position (usually associated with Wittgenstein) has been adopted by many; for instance, W. D. Hudson, P. M. van Buren, D. Z. Phillips, P. Winch, etc. For critiques of this position see, for example, Roger Trigg, *Reason and Commitment* (London: Cambridge University Press, 1973), chapter 4; or Vernon Pratt, *Religion and Secularisation* (London: Macmillan Press, 1970), pp. 37–45. The descriptive versus non-descriptive debate has been well presented by M. J. Charlesworth (ed.), *The Problems of Religious Language* (Englewood Cliffs, N. J.: Prentice-Hall, 1974).

facet of the world where such a judgement is made on reflection on changes in concepts; but Kaufman seeks to base his God idea on common use as well.) That for Kaufman is his starting point and not an observation he makes along the way.

Kaufman would suggest that it is the claiming of theological constructive language as objective truth or descriptive of an objective reality which has lead to our present anarchical ferment in theology, when the objectivity of such symbols falls and the firm base for theology thaws.¹ His suggestion echoes a modern tendency I think overcautious against being proved wrong once again, but I am afraid will fall short in its attempt to establish an adequate theology. Earl MacCormac has made an equivalent suggestion for science and theology by asking that we no more take our (metaphorical) theories as literal truth, that is, in his terminology, as myths. Doing this, he suggests, does not help the consideration of new hypotheses. He also says there are metaphorical theories which can rightfully be taken as literal truth: those theories which have passed into ordinary language, which have thorough empirical support and have lost all their tentativeness.² Kaufman too places truth in ordinary language use in that he seeks to draw his understanding of God from common language.

The problem with Kaufman's prescriptive starting point is that it is also relative and may be surpassed; it is not necessarily an absolute (logic is relative) which will stand for all time. To prescribe such a thing as eternally basic to theology may be just to ensure the theology's replacement later on. It is a big step from showing the inadequacies of taking theological language as objective (especially of past objectivisms) to saying it is not objective and God is purely a linguistic function at base. *I think there is an intermediate path, and that is to acknowledge former objective theological language as inadequate, but to assert some objective language is more adequate than others.* This I plan to discuss later. We can admit that our objective descriptions are inadequate without going to the extreme of saying there can be no objective description at all.

Another theological epistemology

Kaufman's method for finding a theological starting point, and his starting point or basic theistic conception itself, both seem to falter. Yet he is bravely facing telling and cutting objections to theological language and the weakening and confusing torrent of recent theological claims. We need to face the problem of the relationship between theological language and the chief referent of such language, namely God. But we need to do this without accepting Kaufman's suggestion that the actual reality God (the real God) is utterly beyond all language and description. It may be that we can maintain the belief in the objective existence of a perceivable God and yet answer

¹ Kaufman, *Essay*, pp. 35-7.

² Earl R. MacCormac, *Metaphor and Myth in Science and Religion* (Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 1976).

the problems which have caused Kaufman to abandon this epistemology.

(a) *Conflicting epistemologies*. This problem for theology is, in fact, much the same as that being faced by the philosophy of science. There has been in the recent past a strong move to saying that scientific language accurately describes the actual nature of external reality. Relativistic positions, however, have reacted by suggesting that scientific theories *define* what is real, that there are no independent objective criteria or standards, no such thing as description of an objective reality. Rather, there are only elaborations of systems of human ideas. Kaufman reflects that subjectivist swing in the philosophy of science.

Mediating swings against this relativism suggest there is an objective reality which our theories do in some way (as yet not totally delineable) describe, and there is an objectivity or rationality which can to some measure stand independent of theories, and allow for communication and judgement between them. Science is descriptive of physical reality, symbol assumed to exist and assumed to be amenable to scientific analysis.¹ Science is objective to an extent and subjective to an extent. The degree of each is unknown and open to debate. It describes an existent reality, and yet that reality is to some extent subjectively constructed.²

Theology, I feel, needs to regain some of that objectivity and descriptiveness for God-language which philosophy of science has regained for physical reality-language.

The problem is an aspect of the problem of the relationship between our experience and our linguistic concepts, between what we experience as real and what we know. Kaufman is justifiably suggesting that experience is dependent on language, that there is no such thing as experience in the raw which we then seek to put into words. We do not experience the real God, but rather if we do experience God it is the available God we experience. And yet it is also apparent that there is an independent reality which moulds our experience and this in turn leads us to search for new language or forms of expression for this experience. The relationship between language and experience is not totally one way or the other. The relationship is very complex and there appears to be no clear overall model for it.

(b) *A mediating epistemology*. Let us assume that theological knowing is much the same as scientific knowing (although there are differences which can be seen as differences in the degrees to which some properties obtain).³ What is the relationship between the reality and the construct, between the physical world and scientific knowledge, and in theology between the reality God and our theology? Does the available constructed God equal in some way the real

¹ Note that 'science' is usually being used in the sense of the knowledge of the physical sciences.

² For a general discussion of this debate see especially Ian G. Barbour, *Myths, Models, and Paradigms* (New York: Harper and Row, 1974), chapter 6.

³ Barbour, p. 145.

God? Do the available, constructed theories of physical reality we call scientific knowledge equal in some correspondence way the real physical reality?

It seems that both extremes – that (all of) scientific knowledge corresponds in some way to independent physical reality, and that all scientific knowledge is nondescriptive and constructive in Kaufman's sense – are inadequate. Both fall into the same trap because both suggest they know something of the actual nature of 'truth' (be that physical reality or the real God): to know that no concepts are true of God or reality requires that we know something truthful of God or reality. A compromise is needed.

Let me suggest that *we cannot know whether or not our theories correspond to what they purport to describe* (their percept); we can never know whether what we think we know is true of reality is in fact true of reality. Perhaps in some cases we can never know whether what we think we know is true of reality is in fact not true of reality, even if certain scientific theories may fail on testing many times. I suggest this epistemological stance because we can never escape our knowledge to test or check the correlation of the knowledge with the percept in question. We should acknowledge an *epistemological agnosticism* as far as this goes. Theories have proved inadequate in the past; they may do so in the future – but there is no guarantee of that.

Theology can be seen as a process of human construction, but it can also be seen as a description of the reality God (which is what it claims in most cases to attempt). Our constructs and descriptions are subject to the reality and are sometimes called into question (which raises the question of criteria for judging theories, something I will shortly discuss). But the actual nature of that reality and its relationship to our constructs, we can never know if we do know. It is the same as in science: the actual nature of physical reality beyond our conceptions of it and its actual relationship to our knowledge of it we can never know if we do know (we can never be sure or certain about). Kaufman went from the objectivism extreme to the other; I am suggesting only half a step.

I should also add that even though we can never know whether what we know of God is true of God, *we need to claim that some things are true (or more true than others)* for there to be authority and moral conviction. It is a matter of choosing the most correct concept. It is possible to hold something as being the most adequate description of reality or truth – and therefore very much like the embodiment of truth itself – but yet at the same time to realise that this knowledge may be superseded by what would appear as more adequate descriptions.

(c) *Physical reality and God.* There is a large question left open, however, by my paralleling science and theology in this way. Science is descriptive of physical reality, and theology is descriptive of God. But physical reality is something we all experience and with confidence know it has existence; if anything is real it is physical reality. It is therefore easy to talk about science

being descriptive. But God is not, apparently, experienced by everyone and assumed to exist by everyone. If the reality is questioned, can we consider theology to be descriptive?

Ours is a particularly science-oriented, physical-world-biased age, when considerations of the nonphysical are minimal. The fact that physical reality does seem more immediate, more real, than does God (and therefore science can more readily claim to be descriptive) speaks more about the influence of our science-oriented language-use over the reality we experience (socially constructed), than about reality itself. In other cultures and ages when different approaches than the scientific and physical-world ones prevail, reality is known differently than we know it. Yet their systems of knowledge can still be seen as descriptive.

Science has it easy in comparison to theology. The reality which science seeks to describe is commonly assumed, and as a symbol (the construct 'physical reality') there is little debate.¹ But the reality which theology seeks to describe needs to be accepted. That is, just as scientists start with the concept physical reality (which they usually do not question since a version of it is generally assumed by their discipline), theologians need to start with a concept God. The basic symbol for God needs to be accepted before theology can begin; theology is descriptive of the basic symbol chosen as God. This is what the following section attempts to elucidate.

CRITERIA FOR THEOLOGICAL DESCRIPTION

We have now to consider two things. The first concerns our essential understanding of the nature of God (equivalent to Kaufman's understanding of God as an ultimate relativizer), and the second concerns the building of a theology upon that basic understanding. I will proceed in that order.

(a) *Basic theistic symbol.* Through the process called secularization, something has been happening with our knowledge and experience of God. God was experienced as (and was) real, as having real existence, and God showed this reality in interactions with people. I take this as primary. People have attempted, however, to understand something of the nature of God, and so have created theologies and special theological symbols. Our problem is that these theological notions (especially those concerned with the nature or being of God as opposed to God's character) have proved grossly inadequate. Our overall understandings of the nature of things (our cosmology or mythology) have changed leaving our understandings of God stranded and unrelated to them. God is real and people's experience of God is real to them, and we need to understand the nature of God in such a way that God is known to be real; that is, our understandings need to be adequate in portraying

¹ The concept physical reality does change. Present investigations into paranormal phenomena, for instance, may force a broadening of the present common scientific image of reality.

the reality of God. Our experience of God, too, in so far as experience is determined by our concepts and the concepts differ from those of the past, will be different from, or grow from, our experience of God in the past. In a sense we come to know more about God, or our knowledge of God grows, as does our experience of God.

What I am saying is this. We first of all must accept that there is a reality called God (at this stage this word is empty apart from the fact that it is a reality). Secondly, we must choose a basic symbol or concept or model for this reality (this concept needs to be so provocative and full of deep mystery that it will be a symbol); for instance, that God is a loving omnipotent being. Often we do not consciously choose this basic model, for it is common to assume it through the language use of a community to which we belong (not that there be, as Kaufman would have it, necessarily a use common to all uses of the word 'God'). A basic concept for God *becomes for us the reality God*, and usually each individual's basic theistic concept remains the same over all his or her thinking and living. Despite this, theology should choose a basic concept for God along critical lines such as I will shortly discuss. Since we cannot know if this basic concept is really of the reality God – even if we assume it is – we can only apply the tests we have, the tools available for choosing the most adequate description. This then becomes central to our description of the reality God. And it may be a true description of that reality, only our epistemological agnosticism means that we can never know if this is so.

(b) *Theological criteria.* A theologian needs to choose his or her starting point, or basic understanding of God, and then proceed by describing and explicating this basic symbol, especially in its relationship with other symbols.

The guidelines for a descriptive theology would be much the same as for descriptive science, and we could for instance, apply Ian Barbour's list:¹ simplicity, coherence (internal consistency and systematic interrelatedness), supporting evidence (the most important criterion according to Barbour, giving a 'faithful rendition of the areas of experience taken to be especially significant'), extensibility of application (adequately interpreting other events), and comprehensiveness.

Once we have decided on the basic symbol for God we can construct and evaluate a theology bringing in other symbols onto the commonly assumed basic symbol as considered appropriate. Such an evaluation could be made along the lines suggested by Barbour's criteria for judging between competing constructed systems.² Now theological critique becomes like the criticism and communication between competing scientific schools of thought: theirs are secondary criteria because their choice of a basic objective symbol (physical reality) is usually commonly assumed.

¹ Barbour, p. 143. See also the list in MacCormac, p. 151.

² See also Jones, pp. 96–7.

There are many questions of a general nature that can be applied to any set of criteria. From where do they come? What gives them a standing over thought systems, and why should they have this status? Is the choice still only a relative one? Should a set of concepts be tested in all their parts, as a whole unit, or in small segments? When does a test decisively prove against a system? How much secondary elaboration should be tolerated? And if we consider the criterion of humanization in particular (one of Kaufman's criteria), is a theory really testable against this since the process of proving it may take a lifetime and the theory might find itself outmoded once it is found acceptable? Moreover, can humans be left with the task of deciding what it should be to be humanizing, determining the best possible way of life for a human being?¹ Such questions as these are not in any final sense answerable, but we can look for criteria which are shared by our communities.

(c) *Basic symbol choice.* It is important to note two things about the basic symbol choice. The first is that the basic God-symbol be chosen such that *it is felt to be true, to have real existence*, that is, it needs to be generally used as real and essential in our common discourse. This is necessary for people to feel that the God they discuss is indeed the God they know as real, and for the ethical code which religion supports to be felt as binding.

There also needs to be, if this concept of God is to be truly a *Christian* God (if that is what we are seeking) – that is, an adequate conceptualization of what Christians have known and experienced as (their) God – a continuity between the symbol God as explicated and the formulations, understandings and experiences of God from our Christian past. The basic symbol chosen as God must be amenable to such continuity. (It still remains to say what constitutes a specifically Christian theology, what is adequate in terms of the above; ‘by what criteria [can] “proper” conceptions of God...be distinguished from other conceptions masquerading as the concept “God”?’).²

The requirements of the basic symbol chosen for God that it be felt as real and that it be continuous with the Christian tradition, are part of a larger question which needs to be asked of the basic symbol choice: does the basic symbol have the potential of portraying adequately necessary supporting evidence? This includes the considered essentials for Christian theology, and those areas of life itself which are considered important. It ties in also with Barbour's criterion of extensibility: (to use Kaufman's terms) does the basic symbol have the potential of leading to a ‘fruitful life, in the broadest and most comprehensive sense possible’?³

I should note too that there is still a difference between a theologian's selecting a truth-defined symbol as basic for the conceptualization of God

¹ See Campbell, pp. 4–5, and Kaufman, ‘Christian Theology and the Modernization of the Religions’.

² Runzo, p. 686.

³ Kaufman, *Essay*, p. 72.

and that symbol being seen as God by the person in the pew or the person in the street. This even though such a person might recognize the objective existence of the symbol's referent, because he or she fails to associate it with the word God. If the theology is successful in terms of the criteria I have laid out and it receives wide acceptance, gradually it may be that the concept suggested as the reality God becomes for most people an adequate description of the reality God, and thus the basic concept itself becomes identified with the reality God.

(d) *Kaufman's theology as Description.* Note how closely the criteria given above parallel Kaufman's guidelines for his understanding of constructing the concept God (on p. 174 above), plus the overall criterion of it leading towards fuller humanization. There is one important difference, though, between these two activities, and that is Kaufman's first criterion of the formal relationship between God and the world he relativizes absolutely. But this merely reflects Kaufman's choice for a basic theistic symbol, his ultimate limiter, which could be included as part of 'supporting evidence' in Barbour's list.

Kaufman sees theological construction as starting once the stand that God is an ultimate limiter has been taken. I see that initial step of Kaufman's also as an act of theological construction, for Kaufman has done what I suggest theology might do. He has selected a basic symbol for God (as ultimate relativizer) – even though this be a logical function – and would seek to explicate this in his three-fold movement for theology. All of his theology is primarily subject to that one basic symbol, a symbol I think inadequate.

It could be said then that theology is descriptive and yet is much the same enterprise as Kaufman sees it being. It is a matter of selecting a basic symbol for God which is generally felt to have real existence, and then expanding and adding to it along the lines of the criteria given.¹ There is a percept called God and a theology can be judged on its accuracy in describing that percept both in its basic choice of symbol and its elaboration on that choice, besides Kaufman's criterion of humanization. This is necessary if believers' belief in the objective reality of God be taken seriously.

CONCLUSION

We emerge from this discussion of Kaufman's *Essay* recognizing four things. (1) The constructive nature of theology is a process of creating models and metaphors. (2) The starting point for theology is that hub symbol God. Theology starts by examining and constructing the concept God. (3) There

¹ In his later paper, 'Christian Theology and the Modernization of the Religions', Kaufman suggests that we recognize the existence of an extra-human force in the cosmos which is working towards our humanization; this he calls God (pp. 101–4). Is Kaufman selecting another basic symbol for God? Is this symbol part of his real God or his available God? He is being, it is interesting to note, overtly Teilhardian here; see Idinopulos, p. 721.

are criteria for assessing theologies including the basic symbol chosen for God, in that these are implied by or are accepted by competing theological perspectives. (4) There is a tension between theology's being subjective and its being objectively descriptive of some percept called God. It can be neither extreme. I have presented a case in which theology needs to be descriptive, but chiefly descriptive of a basic symbol assumed (or chosen) to represent the reality God. This is much the same as science's assuming a universal basic symbol, namely physical reality, which it then proceeds to describe. Whether the description accurately portrays that being described, one can never know.